The Mihai Eminescu Trust

NEWSLETTER 2011

The high point of the year was the official opening in Viscri of the first ecological sewage treatment plant in Romania by HRH the Prince of Wales. This project was predominantly financed by the Prince, with additional funding from Rompetrol. By filtering waste through soil, ponds and natural reed beds, this pioneering system has enormously improved the living conditions of the Viscri villagers, while causing minimal impact on the traditional environment. Moreover, because the scheme operates without electricity, the householders have no running costs - and its implementation came to a third of the installation cost of a typical modern sewage programme. A small MET information brochure has been published with a detailed description to encourage other communities to copy this form of chemical-free wastewater treatment. The project is part of our ongoing rural development programme in the Bunesti commune.

THE WHOLE VILLAGE PROJECT

VISCRI

Projects were completed on houses No 83, 63, 32 and 41, as well as considerable restoration work on the windows of the MET office and the school. In November, the MET organized a first public hearing in Romania for the protection of rural heritage. The Trust invited to Viscri specialists, local residents, public authorities, regional media and other stakeholders to give their opinion on solutions (suggested by the MET) for building up a local system of heritage protection. More than 40 participants attended and supported the Trust's action call. The report of the public hearing summarised opinions with a set of 11 recommendations, which included producing an easy practical guide of urban planning regulations, strengthening existing legislation and training local volunteers to monitor their heritage. All these recommendations (available in the office), can be applied at the national level for all rural areas through well planned programmes. On May 9th Caroline Fernolend, vice president of the MET, received in Viscri Moisa Ionel Sorin, from the office of Dacian Ciolos, the EU Agricultural Commissioner, who enthusiastically endorsed the work of the MET.

CRIT

Work in Criț continued throughout the year on three facades, Nos 57, 80 and 78, and on a wall for house No 120, a roof for No 14 and the barns of Nos 122 and 181. The MET succeeded in preventing the demolition of a beautiful 18th century stone house in the heart of the village and its removal stone by stone to the Village Museum in Bucharest. Instead, the Trust suggested finding a destroyed house for the Village Museum and restoring it on site in Bucharest or alternatively building a new Saxon house, using traditional materials and methods. Both proposal were refused but the Museum found a house to its liking in Dealu Frumos, which will be "transferred" to the Museum.

ROADES

During 2010-11 the MET motivated and gave support to the Peter Maffay Foundation to take over and carry on the development of the Whole Village Project started by the Trust in 2004. The first stage of the new complex development was inaugurated in July, in the presence of the Ministry of External Affairs, the Ministry of Regional Development and Tourism, the Federal German Ministry of Culture and Media, several Secretaries of State, clerical representatives, mayors and the inhabitants of the commune.



Peter Maffay, Caroline Fernolend, Elena Udrea

Caroline Fernolend managed the event as well as the promotion of the commune and the MET's achievements there.

ARCHITA

Colin Richards and his Shropshire team organised a practical training session in wood joinery during June. Local craftsmen worked on correcting a bad roof restoration on house No 253, where the traditional shape had been altered. The owners were pleased by the result and used

window and shutter hinges in the traditional style from the Viscri blacksmith workshop. The house owners also provided delicious daily lunches for all the members of Colin Richards team during the session. We gave a grant to convert a barn and establish a dried herb business. The herbs are packaged and sold from the village.

MALANCRAV

The Trust has completed 6 projects including advice and support to house No 103, interior and exterior work on the Saxon church, and completing facade No 98 and barns Nos 190 and 335. The Malancrav orchard changed management in the middle of 2011. The new administrator, Daniel Marton, produced a business plan, cleared the orchard's dead wood, repaired the barn roof next to the workshop, and bought or mended equipment and tools. Organic apple juice is the orchard's main output - a high quality product, which also supports employment in the village. This year 28,000 litres of apple juice were produced and supplied to organic shops, restaurants, cafés, private individuals and traditional or Slow Food markets. The vision for the future will concentrate on planting new apple trees, preparing high quality soil and tree maintenance, and diversifying the orchard's products. 1,200 saplings were planted in 2011 and another 3,600 are planned for next year. Daniel is also establishing a nursery for ancient varieties.

FLORESTI

The facade and windows of house No 22 were restored. Visitors continue to enjoy staying in the guesthouse in the village and a Spring Festival Concert of Scarlatti, Bellini and Puccini was held in the church. A tea party followed to welcome the great great great great grandson of Count Bethlen, who had laid the church foundations in 1424.

NOU SASESC

The exterior of the exquisite little 18th century Greek Orthodox church in the hills above Nou Sasesc has now been restored - in memory of our architect Gabriel Lambescu. We cannot recommend highly enough that visitors make a special detour to discover this gem with its glimmer of early frescoes.

RICHIS

After the successful restoration of the Richis church roof and two of the facades of the adjacent Town Hall, the hall is being restituted to the Saxon community for the possible use as a tourist centre and shop. The Trust began another project on the village hall. To our great pleasure 12 Richis builders volunteered to work on the restoration. In return, we signed an agreement with the Evangelic Church for them to use the hall rent-free for 3 family events each.

The importance of this huge undertaking (sponsored by Horizon Foundation) lay not only in the building's history and its architecture, but in the value for the village community. It is now possible to hold village dances, daily kindergarten, school events, weddings, baptisms and funerals in the hall. 8 tables and benches to seat 40 have been sponsored through the MET and made by the Richis carpenter. It is hoped that this hall will be the centre for a literary festival to be held in Richis and the surrounding villages in early October 2012. The work ran exceptionally well under the supervision of Alexandru Neagu and our Richis coordinator. Andrea Rost is recording village memories of the history of Richiș with the local church keeper, Mr. Schaas, in preparation for a book.

The MET joined a campaign to save the 19th century Saxon composer Georg Meyndt's house opposite the church (in the conservation zone). Partial success followed with the exterior remaining all but intact, but the interior was turned into a supermarket.



Georg Meyndt's house in Richis

ALMA VII

Now that the Old School is up and running, it is proving a perfect environment for seminars and a place for guests to stay. At the request of Alma Vii villagers, the Trust organised 12 English language courses. Particular emphasis was laid on basic grammar and work-related phrases needed for farming, masonry, carpentry, building and tourism. The classes started with 46 people, 38 from Alma Vii, two from Medias, four from Biertan and one each from Copsa Mare and Ighis. Despite the initial enthusiasm, only 14 people completed the course and received diplomas. A practical handbook was published and each graduate received a copy.

Work was completed on the facade, doorway, interior and barn of the Trust's guesthouse No 103. An MET grant has enabled the carpentry workshop to be set up. It is now operating successfully as an independent busi-

ness. Work on laying floors and improving the interior of the medical centre has been completed and a German foundation will be generously providing medical equipment and furniture. The Trust's architect's plans for the fine Saxon church are underway. An archaeological dig was conducted in the church precincts.

RESTORATION OF FORTIFIED CHURCHES

The EU funded restoration project for Transylvania's 18 fortified churches has had mixed success so far. Two of the eight churches in our area which had been put under the control of large contractors - Crit and Mesendorf - were found, on inspection by us, to have been using the wrong materials according to the contract agreement. Consequently, work had to be undone and restarted. In Apold, Sebastian Bethge has been on site much of the time and the work has gone well. Work has also gone well on Archita church.

MET CAPACITY BUILDING PROJECT

This year-long programme of meetings, seminars and archive planning (supported by our partner, the Horizon Foundation) involved all our MET colleagues during 2011. Four objectives have been achieved:

- To create a photographic and written inventory of the Trust's projects over the past 11 years.
- To create an internal working documentation for future projects.
- To set up an on-line library of MET publications
- To define a development strategy for the next five years.

In analysing the Trust's work since 2000, a far higher number of projects than originally recorded were identified - 1041 projects in all. These have now been categorised into 11 project types and the Trust has built a solid foundation for the future, consolidated old friendships and identified new partners.

EEA FUND FOR LANDSCAPE CONSERVATION

Funded by the governments of Iceland, Liechtenstein and Norway through the EEA, the Trust, in partnership with the Lutheran Church and City Council of Bunesti, developed during May and June the project "Conservation of historic landscape of the Saxon villages of Transylvania".

The achievements of this project are:

- Restoration of the Malancrav fortified church and its German school.
- Provision of an exhibition space in the precincts of Malancrav's church.
- Restoration of house no. 129. and the Viscri community barn which is being transformed into a processing and marketing area for traditional products.
- Establishing heritage training and information centres in Viscri and Malancrav. Both locations are now equipped to host seminars and workshops. During 2011 there were 6 courses with 81 people trained in traditional carpentry and masonry.
- Preparing urban plans for 10 villages in the Bunesti and Laslea communes.
- Printing 5000 leaflets advising on practical maintenance and conservation measures for owners of historic buildings.
- Printing 1000 copies of the Historic Buildings Guide Book in Romanian and English.
- Producing 500 copies of a documentary film on Saxon village heritage and its history.

To ensure the preservation of these European historic sites, our philosophy seeks to motivate local residents to maintain and care for, not only their buildings but also the well being of the whole village. By promoting and preserving their own village cultural heritage, the occupants realise a strong, direct benefit to their lives.

BREITE OAK PLATEAU

Over the last 5 years the Trust has completed scientific studies and research on Breite, published its findings in prestigious international magazines and built a complex data base and inventory of the oaks and of the fauna and flora of the plateau. Invasive trees and plants have been cleared and oak saplings protected; controlled sheep and goat grazing has been introduced; and a permanent rangers' service has been created, as well as a waste management system. The Trust has also instituted a vibrant programme of ecological and cultural events on the plateau, involving schools and the people of Sighisoara. See MET website / Natural Heritage: www.mihaieminescutrust.org

"PLANT FOR THE PLANET" and "A FOREST FOR EVERY SCHOOL"



This tree planting project, which has been funded by the ACCOR hotel group, has been made possible from the savings achieved by hotels across Europe in not changing the towels daily, every time a towel is re-used by a customer, the hotels pay to charity 50% of the saved cleaning charge. The MET's massive tree planting operation during the year has concentrated mostly on areas of deforestation - in Rupea, Homorod, Jibert, Bunesti and Sighisoara communes - and has involved local schools, villagers, foresters and officials in the mayoral offices. By engaging the community, and laying special emphasis on ecological education with the schoolchildren, we hope to ensure the woodlands' long term future.

NATURE AND LOCAL COMMUNITIES

In 2011 the Trust joined a Transylvanian nature conservation partnership coordinated by WWF Romania.The Breite Oak Reserve is one of the key objectives included under the study part of the four-year project for the Hartibaciu - Târnava Marea area – 267, 000 hectares covering the hydrographic basin and the Olt river. The goal is to develop a framework for land management and the conservation of vital habitats. The grant awarded to this project is 3.4 mil EUR.

SPREADING THE MESSAGE DURING 2011

Jeremy Amos gave a talk in January for the second year running, to both post graduate years of the Conservation Course at London's Architectural Association.
Colin Richards held a meeting and showed a film at the Charlton Arms in Ludlow in January on the work achieved with the MET. Present were MET trustees and all the Shropshire based craftsmen who have been to Romania to give of their time and share their skills.
Caroline Fernolend met with EU Commissioners in Brussels in February and gave numerous presentations throughout the year. In March she spoke in Beia about the Whole Village Project and in April she spoke in Nantes, France, about Roma integration in the Project. In May she attended the opening of an exhibition in Bucharest on "Transylvania's Fortified Churches" and confirmed a partnership between the MET, the Bucharest Academy of Economic Studies and Patrimark. In June she gave a presentation to students from BBB Cluj. In July she spoke about the Trust in Roades. In November she spoke on the Whole Village Project in Ghent, Belgium, and in the same month, along with the architect Leoncio Orellana, she gave a presentation and signed a partnership agreement with Proyecto Pedagogico de Pusol in Spain. In December she gave a lecture about the Trust's work at the University of Cagliari in Italy and also signed on behalf of the MET a partnership with PressTour FIJET Romania. PressTour FIJET will promote the MET's activities for the revitalization of local communities and the conservation of Romanian cultural and natural heritage.
Michaela Tuerk gave two village presentations in March in Stejareni and in Porumbacu De Sus. In August she gave another to the Rotary Club in Sighisoara.
Martin Drury, Chairman of the Landmark Trust, opened the exhibition "Restoration and Revival in Transylvania" on July 8th at the Court Barn Museum, Chipping Campden. He praised the Trust and described his visit with Jessica Douglas-Home to Transylvania in 2006.
Jessica Douglas-Home (MET Chairman) and **Noel Malcolm** (MET Trustee) gave a talk a week later on the MET's work, also in Chipping Campden.
Dr. Tibor Hartel spoke in December on "Leadership In Communities and Organizations" to the Rotary Club, Sighisoara.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

We are most grateful to the Horizon Foundation for its financial support and continued invaluable advice; to Accor for its magnificent donation; to Lizzie van Nieuwenhuyse and the Planet Foundation, to Nancy and Howard Marks Agrinatura Group in Romania; to Dr. Klaus von Lindeiner in Germany and to the many tourists, particularly British, for their generous contributions. We thank Colin Richards and his team from Shropshire which, because of the commitment of Colin Richards and others, continues to transform our work. We are grateful to Yannis Karamitsios for 250 fruit saplings donated to 12 Malancrav families. Finally, we will never forget the Packard Humanities Institute's wonderful support over the Trust's 12 formative years. We are enormously indebted to our Saxon Romanian Director, Caroline Fernolend, without whose energy, inspiration and initiative the projects we have described could not have moved forward as they have.

OTHER INFORMATION

The achievements of the Trust are only made possible by your donations. Please send any offering to either of our offices. Over its first 12 years the MET benefited from the remarkable generosity of the Packard Humanities Institute. Their programme of giving came to a conclusion last year so, in order to continue with our restoration projects we must look elsewhere for our fund raising, which makes every grant or donation all the more valuable.

63, Hillgate Place, London W8 7SS. or 10 Cojocarilor Str, Sighisoara 545400, Jud. Mures

Registered charity no 1107300